JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 2: Government Services & Citizen Rights

Module 6 - Public Services & Utilities

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Public Services & Utilities** — covering Electricity, Water, Gas Connections, Postal Services, the Public Distribution System (PDS), Railways, Public Transport, Municipal Services, and Property Tax Basics. These are the everyday services that quietly keep daily life running, and knowing how each one works helps you use them efficiently and resolve problems quickly.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand India's core public utilities and how to access them.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Understand how electricity, water, and gas connections are provided and billed
- Use postal services and the Public Distribution System (PDS) effectively
- Navigate railway and public transport services confidently
- Understand core municipal services and how property tax works
- Know which authority to contact for each utility issue
- Apply practical habits to manage utility connections and payments smoothly

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Why This Topic Matters

The **Jal Jeevan Mission** has connected over **15.72 crore rural households** to tap water since 2019 — up from just 3.23 crore, covering more than 81% of rural India. **India Post**, over 150 years old, operates through more than **1.64 lakh post offices**, while **Indian Railways** carries an average of **2.3 crore (23 million) passengers every single day**.

> *Reality Check: Many citizens face avoidable delays with utilities simply because they don't know which specific department or portal handles their issue — a water complaint sent to an electricity board, or a municipal issue raised with a state department.*

These services form the invisible infrastructure of daily life. Understanding how each one works — and who's responsible when something goes wrong — saves real time and frustration.

Introduction

Public utilities in India are delivered through a mix of central schemes, state-run boards/corporations, and local municipal bodies. This module covers nine essential services:

- **Electricity** — supplied via state Electricity Boards/Discoms

- **Water** — increasingly delivered through the Jal Jeevan Mission and municipal water departments
- **Gas Connections** — LPG cylinders and piped natural gas (PNG)
- **Postal Services** — India Post's vast physical and financial service network
- **Public Distribution System (PDS)** — subsidised food grains through ration shops
- **Railway Services** — India's massive rail transport network
- **Public Transport** — state road transport corporations, city buses, and metro systems
- **Municipal Services** — local civic services like sanitation and roads
- **Property Tax** — the local tax funding municipal services

Fundamental Concepts

Who Provides What

Utility	Typically Provided By
Electricity	State Electricity Board / Distribution Company (Discom)
Water	Municipal Corporation (urban) / Gram Panchayat & Jal Jeevan Mission (rural)
Gas (LPG/PNG)	Oil marketing companies (LPG) / City Gas Distribution entities (PNG)
Postal Services	Department of Posts (India Post), Government of India
PDS/Ration	State Food & Civil Supplies Department
Railways	Indian Railways (Ministry of Railways)
Public Transport	State Road Transport Corporations / Metro Rail Corporations
Municipal Services	Municipal Corporation/Council/Nagar Panchayat
Property Tax	Local Municipal Body

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Electricity Services

How it works: Electricity is generated by various producers but distributed to homes by state-run or private Distribution Companies (Discoms). Bills are based on metered consumption, with many areas transitioning to **smart meters** for real-time, accurate billing.

Why it matters: Nearly universal household electrification was achieved through the **Saubhagya scheme**, making electricity access close to universal across Indian villages.

Common issues & resolution: Billing disputes, outages, or new connection requests are typically handled through the Discom's helpline, app, or website — most now offer online complaint tracking.

Part B — Water Services

How it works: Urban water supply is managed by Municipal Corporations; rural water supply has been transformed by the **Jal Jeevan Mission**, launched 15 August 2019, aiming to provide a Functional Household Tap Connection (FHTC) to every rural home.

Indian context: Rural tap water coverage rose from just 17% in 2019 to over **81%** by late 2025, covering more than **15.72 crore households**, with the mission's target now extended to 2028 for full coverage.

Common issues: Water quality concerns can be reported to the local Gram Panchayat/Village Water & Sanitation Committee, which also typically manages minor operational costs.

Part C — Gas Connection

LPG (Liquid Petroleum Gas): Domestic cylinder connections are issued by oil marketing companies; the **Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY)** provides deposit-free connections to women from poor households, reaching over 10.58 crore connections.

PNG (Piped Natural Gas): An increasingly available alternative in many cities, delivered directly via pipeline by City Gas Distribution entities, eliminating the need for cylinder refills.

Part D — Postal Services

Definition: India Post, run by the Department of Posts, is one of the world's most extensive postal networks, offering mail delivery, Speed Post, parcel services, Post Office Savings Schemes, and banking through **India Post Payments Bank (IPPB)**.

Indian context: With over **1.64 lakh post offices** and around **1.90 lakh** postal staff/Gramin Dak Sevaks, India Post reaches even the most remote villages; IPPB alone has onboarded over **12 crore customers** since its 2018 launch.

Part E — Public Distribution System (PDS)

How it works: Ration cards (covered in Module 2) entitle holders to subsidised food grains from designated **Fair Price Shops**, under the National Food Security Act, 2013. The **One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC)** scheme allows access from any Fair Price Shop nationwide.

Common issues: Stock unavailability or entitlement discrepancies can be reported to the state's Food & Civil Supplies Department, often via a dedicated toll-free helpline.

Part F — Railway Services

How it works: Indian Railways operates one of the world's largest rail networks, with ticket booking primarily through **IRCTC** (Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation) online, at stations, or via authorised agents.

Indian context: Indian Railways carries an average of roughly **2.3 crore passengers daily**, making it central to both everyday commuting and long-distance travel across the country.

Grievances: Complaints can be filed via the **Rail Madad** portal/app, covering cleanliness, safety, staff behaviour, and service issues.

Part G — Public Transport Services

City buses (via State Road Transport Corporations) and metro rail systems (expanding rapidly across major Indian cities) form the backbone of urban public transport. Many cities now offer app-based real-time tracking and digital ticketing (QR codes, smart cards) for both bus and metro services.

Part H — Municipal Services

Municipal Corporations, Councils, and Nagar Panchayats (introduced in Module 1) deliver core civic services: sanitation and waste collection, street lighting, local road maintenance, water/sewage connections, and birth/death registration. Most municipal bodies now offer online grievance portals for reporting civic issues directly.

Part I — Property Tax Basics

Definition: Property tax is a local tax levied by Municipal Corporations/Councils on property owners, funding civic services like roads, sanitation, and street lighting.

How it's calculated: Common systems include the **Annual Rental Value (ARV) system**, the **Capital Value system**, and the **Unit Area system**, varying by city/state, generally based on factors like property size, location, and usage (residential/commercial).

How to pay: Most municipal corporations now offer online property tax payment portals, often with early-payment rebates and penalties for late payment.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Discom	Distribution Company supplying electricity to consumers
FHTC	Functional Household Tap Connection, the Jal Jeevan Mission's core metric
PNG	Piped Natural Gas, delivered directly via pipeline
IPPB	India Post Payments Bank
Fair Price Shop	A ration shop distributing subsidised food grains under PDS
IRCTC	Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation, handling railway bookings
Rail Madad	Indian Railways' official grievance redressal portal/app
ARV	Annual Rental Value, one basis for calculating property tax

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Step-by-Step Understanding

How to Apply for a New Electricity/Water Connection

1. Visit the local Discom/Municipal Corporation office or official website/app
2. Submit proof of identity, address, and property ownership/rental documents
3. Pay the applicable connection fee/security deposit
4. Schedule and complete the technical inspection/installation
5. Receive your connection and account/consumer number for future billing

How to File a Railway Complaint via Rail Madad

1. Open the Rail Madad app or portal, or dial the railway helpline
2. Select the relevant category (cleanliness, security, catering, etc.)
3. Provide your PNR number, train details, and a description of the issue
4. Submit and receive a complaint reference number
5. Track resolution status through the same platform

Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported public initiatives, described for educational awareness.)

- **Jal Jeevan Mission's Rapid Expansion:** Several states and Union Territories achieved 100% rural tap water coverage within just a few years of the mission's 2019 launch, a pace described as one of the fastest infrastructure rollouts in independent India.
- **IPPB's Doorstep Banking:** India Post Payments Bank has used its vast network of postmen and Gramin Dak Sevaks to deliver doorstep banking to remote rural residents who previously had no easy access to formal banking.
- **Rail Madad Adoption:** Since its launch, Rail Madad has become a widely used channel for passengers to report issues in real time during their journey, rather than only after reaching their destination.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: Your household's water taps have gone dry despite being connected under the Jal Jeevan Mission.
Report it to your Gram Panchayat or Village Water & Sanitation Committee, which manages day-to-day operations and maintenance.

Scenario 2: You're travelling by train and notice unclean conditions in your coach.
Use the Rail Madad app to report it in real time, along with your PNR and coach details.

Scenario 3: Your local ration shop claims your entitled grain quota is unavailable.
Contact your state's Food & Civil Supplies Department helpline to report the discrepancy.

Scenario 4: You've just purchased a new home and need to start paying property tax.
Register the property with your Municipal Corporation and check their online portal for your applicable tax calculation and payment method.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **Ministry of Power:** Oversees national electricity policy and Discom regulation frameworks.
- **Ministry of Jal Shakti:** Implements the Jal Jeevan Mission for rural water supply.
- **Department of Posts:** Operates India Post and India Post Payments Bank.
- **Ministry of Railways / IRCTC:** Operate railway services and ticketing.

- **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs:** Oversees municipal governance frameworks, including property tax systems.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
Electricity Act, 2003	Governs electricity generation, distribution, and regulation in India
National Food Security Act, 2013	Legal basis for PDS entitlements
Railways Act, 1989	Governs the operation and regulation of Indian Railways
74th Constitutional Amendment, 1992	Empowers Municipal bodies to levy property tax and deliver civic services

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Rural households with tap water (Jal Jeevan Mission)	Over 15.72 crore (81%+ of rural India)
Jal Jeevan Mission launch date	15 August 2019
India Post offices	Over 1.64 lakh
India Post Payments Bank customers	Over 12 crore
India Post record revenue (FY2025-26)	₹15,296 crore
Average daily Indian Railways passengers	About 2.3 crore (23 million)
PMUY LPG connections	Over 10.58 crore

(Figures are approximate, drawn from Ministry of Jal Shakti, Department of Posts, and Indian Railways publications through 2025–2026.)

Best Practices

- Keep utility account/consumer numbers handy for quick reference during complaints
- Use official apps/portals (Discom apps, Rail Madad, municipal portals) for faster resolution
- Pay property tax within early-payment windows to benefit from rebates where offered
- Report water quality or supply issues promptly to your local Gram Panchayat/Municipal body
- Track PNR and complaint status directly through official railway channels

Common Mistakes

- Contacting the wrong department for a specific utility issue
- Ignoring early-payment property tax rebates and paying late unnecessarily
- Not updating address/ownership details after buying or selling property
- Assuming water or electricity issues will resolve without formally reporting them
- Using unofficial agents instead of official portals for utility applications

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Municipal services and state services are the same thing"	Municipal services are delivered by local bodies, distinct from state departments handling other matters
"Property tax rates are the same across all cities"	Calculation methods (ARV, Capital Value, Unit Area) and rates vary significantly by city and state
"Filing a Rail Madad complaint doesn't really help"	It is Indian Railways' official, actively monitored grievance channel
"Rural water connections under JJM always guarantee water flow"	Coverage figures reflect tap installation; actual daily water flow/reliability can still vary by area
"Ration shop issues can only be resolved by visiting the shop repeatedly"	Most states offer helplines/portals to formally escalate PDS issues

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Use official Discom/municipal/railway apps for complaints	Don't rely solely on informal complaints without a reference number
Pay property tax within early-payment windows	Don't miss rebate deadlines and pay penalties unnecessarily
Report water/electricity issues to the correct local body	Don't assume state-level offices handle purely local/municipal issues
Keep utility account numbers and receipts organised	Don't discard bills/receipts needed for future disputes
Use Rail Madad for real-time railway complaints	Don't wait until after the journey to report an in-transit issue

Safety Tips

For Utility Payments
- Pay bills only through official Discom/municipal portals or authorised collection centres
- Be cautious of unofficial agents demanding cash for "faster" connections or approvals

For Travel
- Book railway tickets only through IRCTC or authorised counters/agents
- Verify ticket authenticity before travel to avoid issues with unauthorised resellers

For Municipal Issues
- Use official grievance portals to create a traceable record of your complaint
- Follow up with reference numbers rather than only verbal requests

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Practical Checklist

- ☐ Know your Discom/electricity provider and account number
- ☐ Confirmed water connection status under Jal Jeevan Mission (if rural)
- ☐ Registered for property tax with the local Municipal Corporation
- ☐ Know how to use Rail Madad for railway complaints
- ☐ Aware of PDS/ration shop escalation channels in your state
- ☐ Saved key utility helpline numbers for quick access

Quick Revision Notes

- Electricity is supplied via state Discoms; water increasingly via Jal Jeevan Mission and municipal bodies
- India Post and IPPB combine postal and banking services across a vast rural network
- PDS/ration shops operate under the National Food Security Act, 2013, with ONORC enabling nationwide portability
- Indian Railways carries about 2.3 crore passengers daily, with Rail Madad as its official grievance channel
- Property tax funds municipal services and is calculated differently across cities (ARV, Capital Value, Unit Area)

Key Takeaways

1. Each utility has a specific responsible authority — knowing which one saves significant time
2. Rural water access has transformed dramatically since 2019 through the Jal Jeevan Mission
3. India Post and IPPB extend both postal and banking services deep into rural India
4. Official apps and portals (Rail Madad, Discom apps, municipal portals) are the fastest route to resolution

5. Property tax, though local, funds services that affect daily quality of life directly

Glossary

- **ARV** — Annual Rental Value, a property tax calculation method
- **Discom** — Electricity Distribution Company
- **FHTC** — Functional Household Tap Connection
- **IPPB** — India Post Payments Bank
- **IRCTC** — Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation
- **ONORC** — One Nation One Ration Card
- **PNG** — Piped Natural Gas
- **Rail Madad** — Indian Railways' official grievance redressal platform

Frequently Asked Questions

1. Who supplies electricity to homes in India?
State-run or private Distribution Companies (Discoms), regulated under the Electricity Act, 2003.

2. What is the Jal Jeevan Mission?
A national mission launched in 2019 to provide a Functional Household Tap Connection to every rural home in India.

3. How much of rural India now has tap water?
Over 81%, covering more than 15.72 crore households, as of late 2025.

4. What is the difference between LPG and PNG?
LPG is a refillable cylinder connection; PNG is delivered continuously through a pipeline.

5. What is India Post Payments Bank (IPPB)?
A banking service run by the Department of Posts, reaching remote areas via post offices and postal staff.

6. How many post offices does India have?
Over 1.64 lakh, making it one of the most extensive postal networks in the world.

7. What is the Public Distribution System (PDS)?
The system delivering subsidised food grains to ration card holders via Fair Price Shops.

8. What is ONORC?
One Nation One Ration Card, allowing ration card holders to access grains from any Fair Price Shop nationwide.

9. How many passengers does Indian Railways carry daily on average?
About 2.3 crore (23 million) passengers per day.

10. How do I file a complaint about a train journey?
Through the Rail Madad app or portal, using your PNR and issue details.

11. Who manages city bus and metro services?
State Road Transport Corporations for buses, and dedicated Metro Rail Corporations for metro systems.

12. What civic services do municipal bodies provide?
Sanitation, waste collection, street lighting, local roads, water/sewage connections, and birth/death registration.

13. How is property tax calculated?
Through systems like Annual Rental Value, Capital Value, or Unit Area, depending on the city/state.

14. Can I pay property tax online?
Yes, most municipal corporations now offer online payment portals, often with early-payment rebates.

15. What should I do if my water connection has no flow despite being listed as connected?
Report it to your Gram Panchayat or Village Water & Sanitation Committee for operational resolution.

16. Is PMUY only for new LPG connections?
Yes, it specifically provides deposit-free new LPG connections to women from poor households.

17. What happens if I don't pay my property tax on time?
You may lose early-payment rebates and could face late penalties, varying by municipal body.

18. Can I book railway tickets without going to a station?
Yes, via IRCTC online or the official mobile app.

19. Who regulates postal services in India?
The Department of Posts, under the Ministry of Communications.

20. What is a Discom?
A Distribution Company responsible for supplying and billing electricity to consumers.

21. Where can I report an electricity outage or billing issue?
Through your Discom's official helpline, app, or website.

22. Are municipal grievance portals available in most Indian cities?
Yes, most municipal corporations now offer online portals for reporting civic issues with tracking.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **"Who Provides What" utility responsibility chart** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Jal Jeevan Mission coverage growth graph (2019 → 2025)** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part B"
- **Rail Madad complaint flow diagram** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **Property tax calculation methods comparison card** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part I"
- **India Post network reach infographic (post offices, IPPB customers)** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part D"

Official References

- Ministry of Jal Shakti — Jal Jeevan Mission statistics and press releases
- Department of Posts — India Post and India Post Payments Bank official statistics
- Ministry of Railways / IRCTC — passenger statistics and Rail Madad documentation

- Electricity Act, 2003
- National Food Security Act, 2013
- 74th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 — municipal governance provisions

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Official Government Website Links

- Jal Jeevan Mission: **https://jaljeevanmission.gov.in**
- India Post: **https://www.indiapost.gov.in**
- India Post Payments Bank: **https://www.ippbonline.com**
- IRCTC: **https://www.irctc.co.in**
- Rail Madad: **https://railmadad.indianrailways.gov.in**
- India.gov.in (National Portal): **https://www.india.gov.in**

Conclusion

Electricity, water, gas, postal services, ration shops, railways, public transport, municipal services, and property tax together form the everyday infrastructure that quietly supports over a billion lives. Knowing which authority handles which service — and using official channels to report or resolve issues — turns confusing bureaucracy into a manageable, navigable system.

This is the next step in your Government Services & Citizen Rights journey with JanGyan. Stay informed, stay proactive, and remember: **the right service, from the right department, resolves faster than you'd expect.**

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